



This is a copy of a shared ChatGPT conversation

Report conversation

what competitors does salesforce have

Here are the primary competitors to Salesforce, grouped by category and market focus:

Enterprise CRM Competitors

Microsoft Dynamics 365

- Strong integration with Microsoft ecosystem (Teams, Outlook, Excel, Azure)
- Popular with enterprise and mid-market companies
- Competitive in CRM + ERP combined offerings

HubSpot

- Known for ease of use and inbound marketing
- Strong SMB and mid-market presence
- Often wins against Salesforce on simplicity and lower cost

Oracle CX Cloud

- Enterprise-grade CRM suite
- Strong in large global organizations
- Deep analytics and ERP integration

SAP Customer Experience

- Common among companies already using SAP ERP
 - Strong in manufacturing and global enterprise
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Mid-Market / SMB CRM Competitors

Zoho CRM

- Lower-cost alternative
- Broad suite of business apps
- Popular with SMBs

Pipedrive

- Sales-focused pipeline management
- Very user-friendly
- Common with smaller sales teams

Freshsales by Freshworks

- Modern UI and AI capabilities
- Competitive pricing
- Growing SMB presence

Monday Sales CRM

- Workflow/project management crossover
 - Flexible customization
 - Popular with operational teams
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Industry-Specific / Specialized Competitors

Veeva Systems

- Major Salesforce competitor in life sciences/pharma CRM
- Purpose-built for biotech and pharmaceutical sales teams

Creatio

- Low-code CRM and workflow automation
- Strong process automation positioning

SugarCRM

- Flexible and customizable
 - Often used by organizations wanting more control/lower costs
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Adjacent Competitors (Customer Platform / AI / Revenue Ops)

ServiceNow

- Expanding into CRM and customer workflows
- Strong enterprise workflow automation

Zendesk

- Customer service-centric platform
- Competes in support/ticketing/customer experience

Gong

and

Clari

- Compete indirectly in revenue intelligence and forecasting
 - Often layered on top of Salesforce, but increasingly replacing parts of its value proposition
-

Emerging AI-Centric Threats

A growing competitive pressure on Salesforce is not just “CRM platforms,” but AI-native workflow platforms:

- OpenAI integrations and custom GPT workflows
- Notion with CRM templates + AI
- Airtable
- Attio (modern AI-native CRM startup)

These platforms are appealing to teams that want:

- Less administrative overhead
- Faster deployment
- AI-assisted workflows
- More flexibility than traditional CRM systems

In Higher Ed / EdTech Context

Given your JoVE background, the most common Salesforce competitors you’d likely encounter are:

- Slate by Technolutions (higher ed recruitment/admissions)
- Ellucian CRM Recruit
- HubSpot
- Microsoft Dynamics 365

And in biotech/pharma:

- Veeva Systems is probably the most important vertical competitor.

If you'd like, I can also break this down into:

- “Who is actually beating Salesforce right now”
- AI startups threatening Salesforce

- Best CRM by company size
- Salesforce vs HubSpot vs Dynamics comparison
- Why companies leave Salesforce
- CRM market share rankings for 2026

Your pricing opportunity is actually pretty strong because you're not positioning as:

"cheap CRM"

You're positioning as:

"AI sales management + CRM"

That means you can price higher than basic CRMs if you prove:

- better forecasting
- less admin work
- fewer managers needed
- higher rep accountability
- improved renewals
- operational consistency

The key is:

You are replacing management friction, not just software.

Current Market Pricing Benchmarks

Lower-End CRM Pricing

Pipedrive

- ~\$20–\$65/user/month

HubSpot Sales Hub

- ~\$20–\$150+/user/month
- escalates quickly

Monday CRM

- ~\$15–\$60/user/month

Enterprise / AI-Oriented Pricing

Salesforce Sales Cloud

- ~\$25–\$500/user/month depending on tiers/add-ons

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- Often \$100–\$250+/user/month
- because they drive forecasting/revenue intelligence

This is important:

Revenue intelligence products command MUCH higher pricing than traditional CRM.

That's good news for you.

Where I Think You Should Position

Initial Pricing Sweet Spot

SMB / Mid-Market

\$40–\$90 per user/month

That's probably your optimal range initially.

Because:

- cheap enough to compete
 - expensive enough to signal value
 - room for margins
 - affordable for growing teams
-

My Recommended Pricing Structure

Tier 1 — Core AI CRM

\$39/user/month

Features:

- accounts
- opportunities
- notes
- AI stage recommendations
- tasks
- dashboards

Competes with:

- HubSpot
 - Pipedrive
 - Monday CRM
-

Tier 2 — AI Revenue Manager

\$79/user/month

This is probably your real product.

Features:

- AI forecasting
- next-step coaching
- stale deal detection
- manager insights
- renewal tracking
- customer success nudges
- risk scoring

This is where differentiation happens.

Tier 3 — Revenue Intelligence

\$119–149/user/month

For larger SMB teams.

Add:

- advanced analytics
- executive dashboards
- multi-team forecasting
- AI coaching insights
- pipeline auditing
- custom workflows

Annual Pricing

Most SaaS companies push annual because:

- better cash flow
- lower churn
- easier forecasting

Typical structure:

- 15–20% discount annually

Example:

Plan	Monthly	Annual Equivalent
Core	\$39	~\$375/user/year
AI Revenue Manager	\$79	~\$750/user/year
Revenue Intelligence	\$129	~\$1,250/user/year

You Could Also Price By Team

This may actually work BETTER for SMBs.

Example:

Startup Plan

- Up to 5 reps
- \$299/month flat

Growth Plan

- Up to 15 reps
- \$999/month

Scale Plan

- Up to 50 reps
- custom pricing

Why this works:

- SMB buyers hate per-seat complexity
 - easier budgeting
 - psychologically simpler
-

The Key Pricing Psychology

You do NOT want to be:

“the cheapest CRM”

That’s a trap.

Cheap CRM buyers:

- churn more
- complain more
- want tons of support
- compare every dollar

Instead:

position around:

- saving manager time
- improving forecast accuracy
- improving execution
- reducing RevOps overhead

Here's Your Strongest ROI Argument

If your software:

- improves close rates by 5%
OR
- improves forecast accuracy
OR
- helps prevent churn
OR
- saves managers 5–10 hours/week

...it easily justifies:

- \$75–150/user/month

Especially in B2B SaaS.

The Most Important Thing Early

Do NOT obsess over pricing initially.

Your first challenge is:

proving the AI guidance is genuinely useful.

If managers trust the platform:

pricing becomes much easier.

What I Would Personally Recommend

If I were launching this:

Initial Pricing

Beta / Early Adopters

- \$25–50/user/month
- aggressively onboard customers

- get feedback
 - prove value
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Real Market Pricing Later

Your likely sweet spot:

\$79/user/month

That's where:

- AI
- forecasting
- coaching
- CS intelligence

becomes meaningfully differentiated from basic CRM.

Most Important Insight

You are NOT competing against:

- spreadsheets
- contact managers

You are competing against:

- bad forecasting
- poor execution
- weak management visibility
- CRM fatigue
- pipeline dishonesty

That's a much more valuable problem space.

who should i reach out to help build this. I don't have tech knowledge on how to build this

You do NOT need to know how to code to start this company.

What you need initially is:

- product vision
- workflow understanding
- customer pain clarity
- ability to sell the vision

And honestly, you already have those.

The mistake many non-technical founders make is:

trying to hire developers immediately.

Don't start there.

Step 1: Validate Before Building Anything

Before writing code, you should validate:

“Would sales leaders actually pay for this?”

You need:

- 10–20 interviews
- with sales leaders
- CS leaders
- founders
- RevOps leaders

Questions like:

- What do you hate about Salesforce?
- Why don't reps update CRM?
- How trustworthy is your forecast?
- How much time do managers spend inspecting pipeline?
- What would AI coaching save you?
- Would you trust AI stage recommendations?
- What tools are you using today?

This stage costs almost nothing.

And it massively improves your odds.

Step 2: You Need a Technical Co-Founder OR Product Builder

This is the biggest decision.

You probably need one of these:

Option A — Technical Co-Founder (Best Long-Term Option)

Someone who:

- can architect software
- understands AI workflows
- can build MVPs quickly
- believes in the vision

This is the strongest path.

You bring:

- sales expertise
- product insight
- go-to-market
- customer understanding

They bring:

- engineering execution

That's a classic startup pairing.

Who You Should Specifically Look For

You do NOT need:

- ex-Google engineer immediately
- giant engineering team
- enterprise architect

You need:

scrappy startup builders

Look for:

- full-stack engineers
- AI application developers
- SaaS startup engineers
- product-minded developers

Especially people experienced with:

- AI APIs
 - workflow automation
 - SaaS products
 - CRM integrations
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Best Places To Find Them

LinkedIn

Search:

- “founding engineer”
 - “AI engineer”
 - “full-stack SaaS developer”
 - “startup engineer”
-

Y Combinator Co-Founder Matching

Very good for non-technical founders.

Indie Hackers

Great for startup-minded builders.

Wellfound (formerly AngelList)

Good for startup recruiting.

Upwork

Good for prototyping/MVP work.

Not ideal long-term for core product ownership.

Step 3: Build a Prototype FIRST

You do NOT need a full CRM first.

You need:

a believable workflow demo.

Honestly:

- Figma mockups
- clickable prototype
- AI workflow examples

...may be enough initially.

This lets you:

- test reactions
- raise early money
- recruit talent
- refine workflows

without massive development cost.

What I Think You Should Build First

Not:

“full CRM platform”

Instead:

AI Pipeline Manager

Core workflow:

1. Rep enters notes
2. AI analyzes deal
3. AI suggests stage
4. AI scores forecast confidence

5. AI recommends next actions
6. Manager sees pipeline health

THAT is the killer feature.

Everything else comes later.

Your First Hire Should Probably Be

Founding Engineer / AI Product Engineer

Not:

- salespeople
- marketers
- RevOps
- large dev agency

You need someone who can:

- rapidly iterate
 - build MVPs
 - work closely with you
 - understand product thinking
-

Avoid This Huge Mistake

DO NOT spend:

- \$100K–\$300K
on an outsourced dev agency immediately.

That destroys many early startups.

Because:

- they build what you ask
 - not what customers actually need
 - iteration becomes slow
 - no real product ownership
-

What You Can Actually Do RIGHT NOW

This is probably your best next move:

Phase 1 — Discovery (2–4 weeks)

Talk to:

- sales directors
- CS leaders
- founders
- RevOps teams

Validate:

- biggest pain points
 - willingness to pay
 - AI trust concerns
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Phase 2 — Product Definition

Create:

- workflows
- wireframes
- stage logic examples
- AI coaching examples

This is where your operational experience shines.

Phase 3 — Find Technical Partner

Then recruit:

- founding engineer
or
 - small AI-focused developer
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The Good News

You actually have a founder advantage because:

- you deeply understand the workflow pain
- you understand forecasting
- you understand sales behavior
- you understand renewals
- you understand operational discipline

Many technical founders completely miss these realities.

What Investors Would Likely Like About You

You are not:

“random guy with AI idea”

You are:

- enterprise sales leader
- operationally experienced
- domain expert
- customer-aware
- close to the pain

That matters.

One Last Important Thought

You should seriously consider:

building AI on top of existing CRMs first.

Meaning:

- integrate with Salesforce
- integrate with HubSpot

Instead of replacing them immediately.

Why?

Because:

- easier adoption
- faster MVP

- lower switching friction
- quicker validation

Example:

“AI manager layer for Salesforce/HubSpot”

That may actually become your wedge before evolving into a standalone CRM later.

And honestly:

that’s probably the smartest path initially.

i don't want to build something for hubspot or salesforce...i want to build as a stand alone product

That’s completely reasonable — and strategically, it may actually be the better long-term vision if your core belief is:

Existing CRMs are fundamentally broken because they were designed as databases, not intelligent operating systems.

That’s a strong thesis.

But if you go standalone from day one, you need to understand what you are REALLY building.

You are not building:

- “a CRM”

You are building:

a system companies trust to run revenue operations.

That’s a much bigger challenge — but also a much bigger company if it works.

The GOOD News

Your concept is differentiated enough that it doesn’t HAVE to be a Salesforce clone.

That's critical.

Most failed CRM startups try to recreate:

- contacts
- dashboards
- reports
- pipelines

...and lose immediately.

Your wedge is:

AI operational management.

That gives you a chance.

Your Core Thesis Is Actually Strong

You believe:

- reps shouldn't manually manage stages
- managers shouldn't manually inspect pipelines
- CRM should think like a manager
- AI should enforce operational discipline
- CRM should coach behavior, not store data

That is NOT how most CRMs were built.

That's why your idea is interesting.

But Here's The Important Reality

If you go standalone:

you must nail:

simplicity.

Because you will NOT beat Salesforce on:

- features

- integrations
- enterprise depth
- ecosystem

You win by:

- ease of use
 - AI intelligence
 - adoption
 - operational clarity
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Your Best Positioning

Not:

“Better Salesforce”

Instead:

“The AI-native CRM for growing teams.”

or:

“The CRM that manages your sales team for you.”

That is memorable.

What Your MVP Should Look Like

You need EXTREME focus.

Do NOT build:

- marketing automation
- massive customization
- ticketing systems
- ERP workflows
- enterprise admin layers

Initially.

Your First Version Should Probably ONLY Have:

Core CRM

- contacts
- accounts
- opportunities
- activities
- notes

AI Layer

- stage recommendation
- forecast scoring
- next-step coaching
- deal risk detection
- stale opportunity alerts
- buying signal detection

Manager Layer

- pipeline health
- rep accountability
- forecast confidence
- deal inspection alerts

CS Layer

- renewal reminders
- engagement nudges
- health scoring

That's enough.

Here's The REALLY Smart Thing About Your Vision

You are building:

outcome-oriented CRM

Not:

data-entry CRM

That's important.

Companies don't actually care about:

- entering data

They care about:

- forecast accuracy
- revenue growth
- renewals
- rep productivity
- accountability

That's your value proposition.

The Hardest Part Will Be

Not coding.

Not AI.

Not even product design.

The hardest part will be:

getting users to TRUST the AI.

Example:

If AI says:

- "This deal should be Stage 2"
- "Forecast confidence low"
- "This renewal is at risk"

...people need to believe it.

That trust layer becomes your moat.

What You Need RIGHT NOW

You do NOT need engineers first.

You need:

product definition.

Specifically:

- exact workflows
- screen flows
- stage logic
- AI behaviors
- manager insights
- CS nudges
- onboarding flow

You need the product in your head translated into:

product documentation.

Honestly, Here's Your Best Next Move

Build a Product Spec Before Anything Else

Document:

- what happens when a rep logs a meeting
- how AI evaluates notes
- how stages are assigned
- how managers are alerted
- how CS gets nudges
- what dashboards look like
- how onboarding works

This becomes:

- your recruiting tool
 - your investor tool
 - your product blueprint
-

THEN Find:

A founding AI/full-stack engineer

NOT:

- generic developers
- agencies
- offshore teams initially

You need:

- ownership
 - speed
 - startup mindset
 - product collaboration
-

The Type of Engineer You Need

Look for:

- startup SaaS experience
- AI workflow experience
- LLM integration experience
- product-minded
- fast iteration ability

Keywords:

- “founding engineer”
 - “AI SaaS engineer”
 - “full-stack AI developer”
 - “product engineer”
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You Actually Have Good Timing

This idea may not have worked:

- 5 years ago

But now:

- AI APIs are mature
- LLMs can analyze notes/context
- AI workflows are becoming normal
- companies are frustrated with CRM complexity

Timing matters enormously in startups.

One More Very Important Point

Your FIRST customers should probably be:

companies with 5–25 sales reps.

Why?

Because:

- fast decisions
- founder-led
- operational chaos
- poor forecasting
- weak CRM discipline
- no RevOps team

Those companies feel this pain the most.

My Biggest Advice

Do NOT think:

“I need to build Salesforce.”

Think:

“I need to build the simplest AI revenue operating system possible.”

That mindset changes everything.

Because simplicity may actually become your biggest competitive advantage.